Stuffed Cabbage



AI-generated serving illustration; parsley is a presentation garnish.

YIELD About 22-24 rolls

PLAN AHEAD 3 days frozen + 24h+ thawing

COOK 3-5 hours, covered

Ingredients

3 medium cabbage heads | **4 onions total** | Frying oil: less than 1/4 cup

MEAT FILLING

2 lb	Ground beef
1 lb	Ground veal (or lamb, turkey or chicken)
1 cup	Carolina Extra Long Grain White Rice, measured dry
1/4 cup	Cold water
2	Fried onions (half the prepared onions)
2	Eggs
Scant ¼ cup	Sugar
Scant ¼ cup	Honey
2-3 tbsp	Tomato sauce (separate from pot cans)
2 tbsp	Honey Dijon mustard
2 tbsp	Sriracha
3 1/4 tsp	Salt
To taste	White pepper, onion powder and garlic powder

POT & SAUCE

Remaining	Usable cabbage, chopped
1 x 32 oz	Jar sauerkraut (include all liquid)
2	Fried onions (remaining half)
1-2	Marrow bones
1 1/3 cups	Sugar (slightly less than 1 1/2 cups)
2 x 28 oz	Cans tomato sauce
About 1 1/2 cans	Water (use the emptied sauce cans)
1-2 tbsp	Spicy brown mustard
1 1/2 tbsp	Salt
To taste	Black pepper

Prepare & roll

1. Freeze and thaw the cabbage in advance.

Freeze the 3 medium heads for about three days. Transfer to a tray or bowl in the refrigerator to thaw; allow 24 hours or more, longer in a very cold refrigerator, until completely thawed and the leaves separate easily.

2. Start preparing the leaves.

Separate the leaves, discard dirty or damaged leaves and the very green outer leaves, and prefer the pale inner leaves for rolling. Squeeze out excess liquid. Carefully shave down the thick, fibrous rib at the bottom center of each rolling leaf so it is thinner and more flexible. Keep the leaf intact: do not cut the rib out completely or cut through the leaf.

3. Prepare the filling while the leaves are being readied.

Chop and fry the four onions, then divide equally between filling and pot. Let the filling onions cool.

Choose your rice method now. Use the 1 cup measured dry, uncooked as usual. Or cook that same cup separately according to the package directions until tender, cool promptly, and leave the grains whole. Use its entire cooked yield instead of the dry rice; do not add another cup. Keep the 1/4 cup filling water. The cooked-rice option is untested and may make more rolls.

Gently combine the beef and the additional veal, lamb, turkey or chicken with the dry rice (or the cooled cooked yield if using that option), 1/4 cup cold water, two fried onions, eggs, filling sugar and honey, tomato sauce, honey Dijon, sriracha and seasonings. Mix only until evenly combined; avoid kneading into a smooth paste.

4. Begin rolling as soon as some leaves are ready.

Place filling on a prepared leaf, fold the sides over it, and roll closed. Keep the rolls reasonably similar in size. Leaf preparation and rolling can continue together; there is no need to finish every leaf before starting the rolls. If working alone, alternate between preparing batches of leaves and rolling.

5. Finish the leaves and rolls.

Reserve enough good whole leaves for approximately 22-24 rolls. Chop all remaining usable cabbage for the pot. Once leaf preparation is complete, finish rolling the remaining filling before constructing the pot.

Layer, cook & finish

6. Build three layers

Usually make three layers. Divide the chopped cabbage, sauerkraut and its liquid, remaining fried onions, tomato sauce, water, spicy brown mustard, sauce sugar and sauce seasonings among the layers.

1 · Bottom layer Start with one marrow bone. Add cabbage and sauerkraut, then rolls. Add approximately one-third of the sauce ingredients, water, sugar and seasonings.

2 · Middle layer Add the second marrow bone here, if using. Repeat the cabbage, sauerkraut, rolls and another third of the sauce ingredients, water, sugar and seasonings.

3 · Top layer Repeat with the remaining cabbage, sauerkraut, rolls and remaining sauce ingredients, water, sugar and seasonings.

7. Simmer & check

Bring the pot to a simmer. Cover and cook at a gentle simmer for approximately **3-5 hours** . Begin checking at about 3-3 1/2 hours.

Check the meat first: insert a food thermometer into the center of the filling in a large roll. For beef with veal or lamb, reach at least **160°F / 71°C** . If using ground turkey or chicken, the entire filling must reach at least **165°F / 74°C** . Check more than one roll, including a roll farther into the pot when accessible.

Then check the texture: split a roll open. The rice should be fully softened, without a hard center, and the cabbage should be tender. Once the temperature check passes, taste to judge texture and seasoning. Continue simmering if the rice or cabbage needs more time.

RECIPE NOTES

The 1/4 cup filling water is a new addition; the optional cooked-rice method has not yet been tested in this family recipe. Filling tomato sauce remains 2-3 tablespoons. Yield and cooking time are approximate.

Use one 32-ounce sauerkraut jar, including all its liquid. Scant means slightly less than the stated amount. Refrigerator thawing and thermometer checks are recommendations added to the family instructions.

REFERENCES

Water in stuffed-cabbage filling
Stuffed cabbage with cooked rice
FoodSafety.gov cooking temperatures
Ba-Tampte 32 oz jar
Gentle meat mixing
Carolina Extra Long Grain White Rice
USDA thawing guidance